

Photos by TITAN



Photo by PIAGET

Clockwise from top: Titan's high jewellery watches, with malachite and aventurine on the dial; Titan's ultra-luxe, in-house flying tourbillon; hand-painted marble dial with royal miniature painting; Vintage Rolex day-date watch with diamonds and coloured gemstones; Titan's high jewellery Genesis Starburst watch.

and Vacheron Constantin; even Cartier had stone dials in its Must de Cartier line, although few executed them as successfully as Piaget. Swiss watchmakers thought less like engineers and more like artists. Gold resembled woven fabric, stone became the dial, and watches were designed to express something beyond the time—emotion, style, and status."

Bespoke Iterations

Rolex took things to the next level in the eighties employing precious gems in bespoke creations. According to David Silver, Rolex Specialist, "it really happened from the 1980s with the explosion of pop culture, Andy Warhol, and the Wall Street boom that made Rolex's Day-Date model a status symbol. Rolex began embellishing those watches with diamonds and coloured gemstones for the Middle Eastern and Asian markets, and these seeped into a micro-collection Rolex themselves called the Crown Collection, which was a play on the Rolex crown, but also the crown of royalty. Each piece had its own unique reference number denoting the gemstones used: a ruby bezel had one reference, a sapphire another, and an emerald yet another. The irony is they were unsalable at the time, far too ostentatious, and 20 years ahead of their time. They sat in retailers' safes for a decade or more, and that's precisely what makes them so rare and coveted today."

The decades that followed were defined by minimalism in fashion, which was reflected in watch designs, which boasted technological superiority with extremely complicated mechanical movements. Popular watch models during this time included Rolex's Submariner, Cartier's Santos, and Omega's Seamaster Professional 300M, which featured prominently in the revival of the James Bond Franchise, worn by actor Pierce Brosnan in Goldeneye.

It was a slow return to colour in watch making. Mining company Gemfields was instrumental is triggering this shift in jewellery and watches with investment in large-scale mining of first Zambian emeralds at their Kagem mine and later rubies at their Montepuez mine in Mozambique. Gemfields also owned the jewellery and watch



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